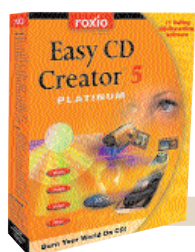


CD WRITING SOFTWARE

There was a time when the only way you could back up and transfer data to another location was through a floppy. This meant that either the capacity of the floppy became a limitation or you had to adopt a proprietary solution like Iomega's Zip drive, which created other issues. The advent of CD-Rs and CD-RWs has solved this problem for most requirements. But working with CD-writers requires the right kind of software. There are a variety of CD writing software that cater to a wide variety of needs, from the do-it-all CD authoring suites such as Easy CD Creator, to other programs which are best suited to performing specific tasks such as CD-to-CD copy, Audio/Video CD writing, Disk image burning, etc.

With more emphasis being laid on a wider support for all the available writers, you can expect to buy almost any CD Writer and start burning. Further on there will be integrated support for detection of newer media formats.

Also, with the arrival of Windows XP, which brings along with it integrated support for CD Writing from within Windows Explorer, it remains to be seen whether stand-alone CD Writing suites will be able to make it on their own.



Easy CD Creator 5 Platinum



This is probably the most extensive software of the lot with many interesting built-in features

This software supports the maximum number of CD Writers and includes several new tools that make it easier to create picture albums, audio CDs and video CDs. The wizard too has been improved significantly and has made the process of writing much simpler. Also included is a new authoring tool for MP3s and support for WMA. All this is in addition to the ability to backup regular data with the simple Explorer style interface, which has drag-and-drop support.

- + Spectacular feature list
- + Extremely simple interface

Price: Not available
Contact: Roxio
Web site: www.roxio.com
Reviewed in: May 2001

Worthy Mentions

Nero Burning ROM 5.5

+ Provides wizards
Price: Free for download
Contact: Ahead Software
Web site: www.ahead.de/en/index2.htm
Reviewed in: May 2001

Easy CD Creator 4 Deluxe

+ Very simple drag-and-drop capabilities
Price: NA
Contact: Roxio
Web site: www.roxio.com
Reviewed in: May 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: NA 1999: NA 1998: NA

DVD PLAYBACK SOFTWARE

When it comes to sheer image and audio clarity of movies, there's nothing that comes close to a DVD. In fact, the primary use of a DVD drive, the prices of which have been doing a freefall, is for enjoying movies. DVD playback software of today tap into the new features and enhancements in today's processors and 3D graphics cards, allowing you to watch full-motion DVD video on your home computer. This allows the software to handle external hardware that supports Dolby Digital audio, HDTV screens, etc.

We can look forward to plenty of added functionality to DVD playback software in terms of support for newer standards such as Dolby Digital, HDTV, etc. Also, since DVD players will become mainstream in the coming year, DVD playback functionality will be integrated into operating systems directly. With greater amounts of processing power available, there could also come a time when Dolby Digital decoding could be implemented in the DVD playback software itself with no need for special external hardware such as AC-3 decoders. Maybe the next movie you watch with all its multi-channel splendour will be due to the advanced functionality built into these software.



Intervideo WinDVD 2000



Advanced control of your DVD movies and a skinnable interface make this software a brilliant choice

With a host of very advanced DVD control and playback features, this DVD playback software sets a new standard in this category. It has support for advanced features such as iDCT, Motion Compensation and multi-channel audio. It also has a skinnable interface, allowing you to download skins and change its outlook altogether. A feature-packed interface makes this software the player of choice when it comes to watching DVD movies.

- + Support for advanced DVD control features
- + Skinnable interface

Price: Not available
Web site: www.intervideo.com

Worthy Mentions

PowerDVD 2.55

+ Multi-channel audio support
+ Skinnable
Price: Not available
Web site: www.gocyberlink.com

Ravisent Cinemaster 2000

+ Very robust DVD decoding capabilities; skinnable
+ Compatible with a wide range of DVD drives
Price: Not available
Web site: www.ravisent.com

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: NA 1999: NA 1998: NA